▼ VIEWPOINT

THE DALAI LAMA AND CHINA'S PLAY

Tibet is a sensitive issue in India-China relations, but pandering to Chinese demands is not the answer

BY ASHOK K. KANTHA

On July 2, just before his 90th birthday, the 14th Dalai Lama issued a proclamation affirming that the institution of the Dalai Lama will continue. He entrusted his Gaden Phodrang Trust with exclusive authority to identify the 15th Dalai Lama, and barred any outside interference. Within hours, China's foreign ministry denounced his proclamation as illegal under their 2007 'Measures on the Management of the Reincarnation of Living Buddhas', which mandate the Chinese government's approval for all high-Lama reincarnations. The fault line thus runs between two rival processes—one administered by the trust on Indian soil, the other to be orchestrated by the Chinese party-state.

The announcement from Dharamshala elicited mixed response from India. Union minister for minority affairs Kiren Rijiju voiced support, stating, "Only the Dalai Lama and conventions established by him can decide his successor." However, the ministry of external affairs (MEA) clarified that the government "does not take any position" on faith-based matters. Rijiju and other government functionaries attended the Dalai Lama's birthday celebrations, while Prime Minister Narendra Modi sent his greetings. The Chinese remonstrated, as they had done earlier after Rijiju's comments. This dissonance reveals India's delicate balancing act. Rijiju's remarks hinted at a potential alignment with the Dalai Lama's vision, but the MEA's clarification signals the desire to avoid provoking China.

China's insistence on controlling the Dalai Lama's reincarnation is a calculated strategy. By anointing a Dalai Lama of its choosing, Beijing seeks to bolster its narrative of historical sovereignty over Tibet. A 15th Dalai Lama backed by China could fracture the unity of the diaspora Tibetan community, quell dissent internally and undermine the moral authority of the Dalai Lama's lineage. A Beijing-approved successor could potentially erode the international support for the Tibetan cause after the demise of a charismatic Dalai Lama.

Illustration by RAJ VERMA

A 15TH DALAI LAMA BACKED BY CHINA COULD FRACTURE THE UNITY OF DIASPORIC TIBETANS AND QUELL INTERNAL DISSENT

India, on the other hand, as host to the Dalai Lama and a large Tibetan community since 1959, and with deep civilisational links with Tibet, has stakes in this matter. It cannot adopt a hands-off stance even while it maintains the official position of not interfering in religious matters, particularly if the 15th Dalai Lama as recognised by the Dalai Lama's trust is born in India. It cannot leave it to the Chinese party-state to control reincarnation of the Dalai Lama and other Tibet-linked reincarnate Lamas in India, in the sensitive Himalayan belt or elsewhere. Apart from Tibet's strategic significance, India has an abiding interest in preserving the Tibetan culture endangered in China. There will be the practical requirements of dealing with the Tibetan community, the Central Tibetan Administration and, indeed, the 14th Dalai Lama's successor if he is identified in India. Correct lessons must be drawn from the inept handling of the succession of the 17th Karmapa.

Tibet is a sensitive issue in India-China relations but pandering to Chinese demands is not the answer. A neutral stance risks ceding the narrative to China, while a bold endorsement could inflame tensions with China. Without explicitly endorsing the Gaden Phodrang Trust's process, India should amplify its support for the Tibetan people's right to preserve their traditions and continue close engagement with the Central Tibet Administration. This discreet support avoids confrontation with China while countering Beijing's efforts to hijack a religious process and signalling that India will only acknowledge a successor chosen through traditional Tibetan methods, not Chinese fiat. To safeguard its interests, avoid undue turbulence in its complex relations with China and yet ensure that the Dalai Lama's legacy echoes beyond his lifetime, India must adopt a nuanced yet firm stance. ■

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